

The Road to the Civil War

Follow the chain of conflicts over slavery's expansion from 1850 to 1861 and decide which link did the most to make war unavoidable.

? Historical challenge

The Civil War did not begin with a single event. Through the 1850s, a chain of conflicts over whether slavery could expand into the western territories pushed the nation toward war — each action producing a sharper reaction. Trace the chain from pressure to consequence, and decide which link mattered most.

1 Investigate

SOURCES 1

Dred Scott v. Sandford (1857) — National Archives

PRIMARY SOURCE

The Supreme Court judgment that denied Black citizenship and struck down the Missouri Compromise.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- What did the Court decide about citizenship and about Congress's power?
- How might Northerners and Southerners react differently to this ruling?

SOURCES 2

Bleeding Kansas — National Park Service

SECONDARY SOURCE

How popular sovereignty turned Kansas into a battleground over slavery.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- Why did violence break out in Kansas?
- How did this deepen the conflict between North and South?

SOURCES 3

Trigger Events of the Civil War — American Battlefield Trust

SECONDARY SOURCE

The escalating chain of events from the Fugitive Slave Act to Fort Sumter.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- Which events form the chain toward war?
- Which one seems to be the point of no return?

2 Build your Event Map

Fill in the organizer from the evidence. Mark information with ①②③ to show which source it came from. Leave a space blank if the sources don't tell you.

PRESSURE

Disputes over whether slavery may expand into western territories won from Mexico (1848–1850).

**ACTION**

Compromise of 1850 and its Fugitive Slave Act (Sept. 1850) — a deal that also forced free states to return escaped people.

**REACTION**

Kansas–Nebraska Act (May 1854) reopens the question by 'popular sovereignty,' leading to 'Bleeding Kansas' violence (1854–1859).

**ESCALATION**

Dred Scott decision (March 1857) denies Black citizenship and any federal power to bar slavery; John Brown's Harpers Ferry raid (Oct. 1859) hardens both sides.

**EVENT**

Lincoln's election (Nov. 1860) leads Deep South states to secede (Dec. 1860–Feb. 1861); Confederates fire on Fort Sumter (April 12–14, 1861).

**CONSEQUENCES**

Outbreak of the Civil War (1861–1865); the Upper South secedes after Sumter; the war becomes one that ends slavery.

Where might events have gone differently?

People / groups responsible

Stephen A. Douglas — authored the Kansas–Nebraska Act and

Which link was most important?

What if the Compromise of 1850 had not included the harsh Fugitive Slave Act — would sectional anger have cooled instead of spreading North?

popular sovereignty

Chief Justice Roger B. Taney — wrote the Dred Scott majority opinion

John Brown — led the Harpers Ferry raid

Abraham Lincoln — whose election triggered secession

Which single link did the most to make war unavoidable — the Fugitive Slave Act, the Kansas–Nebraska Act, Dred Scott, Harpers Ferry, or Lincoln's election? Choose one, and use evidence from at least two other links to defend it.

Sources 1

Sources 2

Sources 3

3

Compare

- Compare your chains with a partner. Did you order the links the same way?
- Did you choose the same 'most important link'? Defend your choice with evidence.

4 Expand

Your teacher will add context, vocabulary, and information the sources leave out. Add it to your map.

TEACHER NOTE

Key ideas

Slavery — and specifically whether it could expand into new territories — was the central cause of the sectional crisis. Each compromise or ruling meant to settle the question instead sharpened it: the Fugitive Slave Act angered the North, the Kansas–Nebraska Act reopened the territories, Dred Scott denied any federal limit on slavery, and Lincoln's election (on a platform opposing slavery's expansion) triggered secession and war.

Common misconceptions

- The war's central cause was slavery, not merely 'states' rights' in the abstract.
- The Compromise of 1850 did not settle the issue; its Fugitive Slave Act inflamed it.
- Lincoln's 1860 platform opposed the expansion of slavery, not (yet) its immediate abolition everywhere.

Vocabulary

sectionalism, popular sovereignty, Fugitive Slave Act, Dred Scott, secession, Fort Sumter, abolitionist, Confederacy.

Historical context

Compromise of 1850 & Fugitive Slave Act (Sept. 1850); Kansas–Nebraska Act (May 30, 1854) & Bleeding Kansas; Dred Scott (March 6, 1857); Harpers Ferry (Oct. 1859); Lincoln elected (Nov. 6, 1860); South Carolina secedes (Dec. 20, 1860); Fort Sumter fired on (April 12–14, 1861).

5 Revise

Go back to your Event Map. Add, correct, or reorganize based on the discussion.

6 Conclude

Which link in the chain did the most to make war unavoidable? Support your claim with evidence from at least two sources and two links.